

RECONSTRUCTION IN A MUSEUM

Some fossil remains are too rare or fragile to be displayed in museums. Skilled technicians make casts of these fossils out of lighter materials, which are then used to reconstruct the dinosaur like a giant three-dimensional puzzle, supported by a metal frame. These models, like the one seen here, are put on display in museums for the public while the real fossils are stored safely behind the scenes for further research.



The positions of all remains are marked on a grid to help paleontologists work out what happened to the body during fossilization.



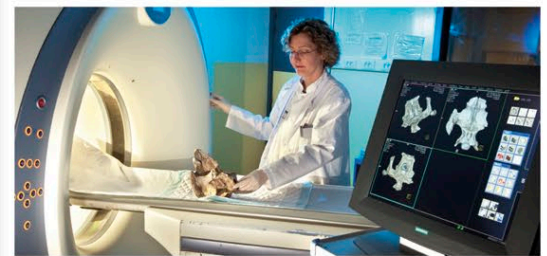
MAKING SENSE OF THE EVIDENCE

Taking fossils out of the ground and rebuilding them for scientists to study is not an easy task and involves several delicate stages. Skilled experts use different tools and techniques to compile the clues that can be found in fossils.



Preparation

First, the rock is cleaned away from the surface of the fossil using delicate drills. This process can take paleontologists thousands of hours.



Scanning the bones

In order to avoid damaging the fossil, researchers study the insides of the bones using powerful scanners.



Filling the gaps

Computer analysis of fossils allows paleontologists to study a find in detail, digitally reconstruct the missing parts, and work out how to repair it.



Creating 3D models

Experts create and print models of the fossils, which allow scientists to examine the fossil without handling the actual specimen.